

Week 8 Lit Example Reader

MACBETH: FAIR, FOUL, AND SHIFTING SECURITY

Purpose: Macbeth passages for Week 8: expose term shifts that make prophecy and persuasion look like stable proof.

What to watch for: Repeated words that do not keep one idea. Ask which sense is operating, and whether an inference still holds when the sense is fixed.

Before the Passages: The Week 8 Logic Tool

- **Equivocation:** one word, two ideas, one argument.
- **Ambiguous middle:** a linking term that only looks shared.
- **Fix the term:** state both senses; rewrite; retest the conclusion.

Passage 1: Act 1, Scene 1 and Scene 3 — Fair, Foul, and Greeting

Context: The witches open the play by joining opposite words. Later they greet Macbeth with titles that sound like facts and promises.

All. Fair is foul, and foul is fair:

Hover through the fog and filthy air.

First Witch. All hail, Macbeth! hail to thee, Thane of Glamis!

Second Witch. All hail, Macbeth! hail to thee, Thane of Cawdor!

Third Witch. All hail, Macbeth, that shalt be king hereafter!

Banquo. Good sir, why do you start, and seem to fear
Things that do sound so fair?

Reader Notes

Here is your most assisted example. *Fair* is doing unstable work. In the witches' chant, fair and foul are forced together so moral and sensory language blur. In Banquo's line, *fair* can mean attractive, promising, or fortunate-sounding. The titles also mix present fact (Glamis) with future claim (king hereafter). Week 8 asks whether a later inference from these words keeps one sense of *fair*, *hail*, or promised greatness—or whether Macbeth treats a shifting verbal surface as if it were one solid middle term.

Reading task: Circle every use of *fair*. Mark which titles are present fact and which are future claim. In the margin, write two possible senses of *fair* in this passage.

Passage 2: Act 4, Scene 1 — Security in the Apparitions

Context: The apparitions give Macbeth statements that sound like safety. Watch the key words that seem to guarantee him.

Second Apparition. Be bloody, bold, and resolute; laugh to scorn
The power of man, for none of woman born
Shall harm Macbeth.

Third Apparition. Macbeth shall never vanquish'd be until
Great Birnam wood to high Dunsinane hill
Shall come against him.

Macbeth. That will never be:
Who can impress the forest, bid the tree
Unfix his earth-bound root? Sweet bodements! good!
Rebellion's head, rise never till the wood
Of Birnam rise, and our high-plac'd Macbeth
Shall live the lease of nature, pay his breath
To time and mortal custom.

Reader Notes

This passage shifts more work to you. Macbeth hears words of security and treats them as a stable guarantee. Mark the phrases that sound impossible. Decide what ordinary sense Macbeth gives *none of woman born* and *Birnam wood*, and what different sense later events use. Do not complete the whole worksheet diagnosis here—only mark the pressure words and possible sense split.

Reading task: Underline the two security promises. Beside each, write one sense that would make Macbeth feel safe. Save the full fixed-meaning rewrite for the worksheet.

How to Use These Passages on the Worksheet

The worksheet asks you to treat prophetic language as an argument with terms. Keep senses separate. A repeated word is not automatically a stable middle.